NOVELISTIC SCREENPLAY

POKÉMON NOCTURNE

EPISODE 15

Vedro con mio diletto

End of the series

Author
Adelbert Vervloet

Working compilation

Status · draft · pass 1/3 recorded · EN-GB apparatus

Format	Novelistic screenplay · EN anchors
Target duration	To be set — corpus ≈ 105 min read aloud
Scenes	19 + final card
Version	2026-09-24 · EN-GB dossier after P1

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Episode sheet

Series Pokémon Nocturne
Episode 15 — Vedro con mio diletto · End of the series
Author Adelbert Vervloet

Logline

Red relearns the rain. Gold/Richter remains a hostage at Cerulean. Skarmory sets Red down at New Bark. The mother finds a son again. The boat leaves. The Coyote smiles without a human motive.

Place in the arc

Due: Red among the living; Apollo gone; Chris/Maria at New Bark.
Paid: Misty; the hostage; the mother; the quay; the montage (Oak, Silver, Apollo, the Coyote, Krise, the kimonos, Chris/Maria).
Open: the Coyote still; the Dex to be democratised; fragile happiness.

Characters — this episode only

Name	Function here
Red · Misty	Cerulean; rain; the hand
Gold/Richter · Chris/Maria	Hostage; New Bark; the quay. she/her for Chris/Maria.
Red's mother	Becoming Your Son Again
The quay	Blue (she/her); Green (he/him); Lance; Eusine
The montage	Oak; Agatha; Mewtwo; Giovanni; Silver; Apollo; the Coyote

Places (EN anchors)

Cerulean · New Bark Town · Pallet Town (quay, house, laboratory) · Goldenrod (park) · Ecruteak · Viridian · Mt. Silver (the gaze only).

Technical notes — outside the scenes

Heading	Note
Vedro card	Exception: the episode title is the piece. The other scenes keep a narrative title.
Coyote	The smile mimics a human motive. The grammar ("it borrows ours"): sheet, not body. Image only.
Comparisons	Interlaken / Basel: intermittent, a gauge for the reader outside the universe. Not a map.
Blue	Always ≠ Green. Same key as Episode 13. she/her.
Hunting crop	niveleur / fouet. Not leveller, not whip.
Imprecation	Frozen from Episode 01. Distinct from the move Curse.
The Third Soul	Scene title. OST cue remains A Third Soul (Nocturne label ≠ narrative title).

Screen durations (excluding titles)

Tumult ≈ 1 min 50–2 min 10. Child ≈ 4–4 min 20. Hostage ≈ 1 min 35–50. Pilot ≈ 1 min 50–2 min 15. Therapy ≈ 3 min 45–4 min 10. Happiness ≈ 3 min 20–40. Vedro: duration of the piece.

BGM index — pieces (Nocturne OST)

Scene	Piece	Range
Misty / the note	Always	00:00–00:30
Misty / Red	We Have Been Waiting	entry
Skarmory	Fire It Is	01:41–end
Therapy	Don't Listen to Her	00:00–01:04
The Third Soul	A Third Soul	00:00–01:30
The mother	Richter My Friend	entry (= scene duration)
The quay	Alone for Many Years	entry
The quay	The Belmont Family	entry
Vedro con mio diletto	Vedro con mio diletto	entry – 03:09

BGM index — traces

Address only.

Scene	BGM
The Tumult of the Age	EP05 S02 01:20–02:48
The Tumult / the house	EP03 S02 08:10–08:50
If You Really Were Still a Child	EP07 S01 17:36–19:00
The Hostage in Exchange	EP01 S02 16:46–17:00
The Alternate Pilot	EP04 S02 18:10–19:00
The Alternate Pilot	EP03 S01 16:54–17:29
The Alternate Pilot	EP01 S02 08:00–08:16
The quay	EP05 S01 18:34–19:24

Order of scenes

1. The Tumult of the Age
2. If You Really Were Still a Child
3. The Hostage in Exchange
4. The Alternate Pilot
5. Alternative Therapy
6. Bureaucratic Felicity
7. The Role of Gym Leaders
8. Fellow Citizen or Stranger
9. The Mutation Contrary to Appearances

10. The Invigorating Succession
11. The Reason for Returning
12. You Wouldn't Regret It
13. Not That Era, but Perhaps Now
14. The Third Soul
15. Now I Have Experienced It
16. Destined for Potential Rather Than Death
17. Becoming Your Son Again
18. Every True Happiness in Its Own Way
19. Vedro con mio diletto

The scenes are inserted here. The close follows the body.

Scene — The Tumult of the Age

, Cerulean — Autumn Night

BGM ‘Ep 05 S02 01:20–02:48’

The city centre still held. Shops were open. Few people were out and about. People went in and out of the shops. Nothing was waiting for anyone.

A teenager approached the frame. A plain pelisse, already too grown-up. A newsboy cap. Not a disguise. A certain bearing. The collar a little too high. The shoulders too self-aware.

No one was looking for him. Giovanni was no longer there. Nor was Rocket. He had been reduced to a symbol, to a convenient hero — and, abstraction aside, people used him as they pleased, without expecting his arrival. The civilians made no effort. No enthusiasm.

A faint sense of relief, barely. Then a clearer disappointment, one he hadn’t anticipated: his past devotion was worth very little. He wasn’t keen on fame. It was something else. Bitter. Ambiguous. It didn’t remind him of Mt. Silver. It left him amongst the masses, out of place in any town — and yet there, because of Misty.

He paused in front of the shop windows. Goods. Publications. He scanned the text too slowly, as one might be relearning a language. A television, further on: intelligible, stripped of all complexity, simplistic, almost repulsive, instinctual, crude. The aversion came without a name. He didn’t know if it was the commotion, the worldliness, or that very obscenity — a vulgar gust after years of silence too thick to bear.

Those he passed showed no interest. This shielded him from conceit. It also consumed him: an anonymous indifference, colder than the mountain.

The fog was hazy, murky, strange. The air was frozen — not by the temperature, any less so than at Mt. Silver — but by a synthetic nonchalance, a human detachment, beneath the streetlamps. A banal enigma. Something to get used to.

He accepted it. He tried to resign himself to the paradox.

Misty’s home — a cloudy day

BGM: ‘EP03 S02 08:10–08:50’

The drizzling rain enveloped the town. Drops clung to the outer pane of the window and trickled down bit by bit.

Inside, the warmth was almost airtight. Sealed in.

Red ran his finger lightly along the window from the inside. As if to feel the raindrops. As if this everyday phenomenon were extraordinary. He was familiar with it in Mt. Silver. What was different *here* was the place, the setting, the people. The familiarity of the rain would not go away. Nor did it help.

Misty wasn’t on duty. She was sitting down. The computer pushed aside — news, posts, things she’d already seen. A physical book, open, which she was barely making any progress with. Almost a pretence. So that he might find a moment of introspection amongst the people.

He was still learning.
His shoulders, always all too aware.
That was everyday life.

End of scene

Scene — If you really were still a child

Cerulean — Misty's home, autumn twilight

BGM 'EP07 S01 17:36 19:00'

The light was already fading in the room. Gold/Richter was taking far too long to get ready for a simple outing. The tailcoat, pinned up, as if for a role. He picked it up, examined it, put it back — then the pockets: phone, wallet. The scarf, a good buy, the collar. As he headed for the door, his body betrayed him. A wobble. The cane. A glance at Red, who was silent. He took his leave.

Red had seen it all. Neutral. Without realising the significance. Gold/Richter looked as though he were going out on someone else's behalf.

Outside, the step. Without the walking stick, he wouldn't have managed it. The difficulty remained unclear, like everything that was no longer Mt.Silver.

—

The living room. Tea still warm. A magazine lying open that Misty had stopped turning the pages of. Red, on the other sofa, reading a publication with a more feminine cover. She gave him that look — lingering, already teasing.

"Didn't you have anything better to read over there…?"

He sensed the implication. Reluctance.

"Yes. But not always books."

"Oh. Your way of reintegrating into society? The more timeless books."

"They actually serve a purpose."

"Why that novel? Weren't there any women in it?"

"Yes. It was almost the same as with men."

"With girls, it's even rarer."

"Yes."

He tried to change the subject. She didn't let it go.

"Have you forgotten how to deal with women…? And what they might be thinking…"

'Books of that sort allow me to do so.'

'Is that really your intention…?'

A dead end. He closed the novel. For the first time since his return, he really looked at her.

‘Doing the same thing makes us feel differently depending on where we are. I need to find my feet again.’

His words faltered for a moment. Then, more cautiously:

“You’ve taken on a new mood… teasing, sarcastic… Like a grudge…?”

“Just so my feelings aren’t… maternal. A bit of sarcasm serves to set you straight. Without humiliating you.”

“Ah. I see.”

Unease lingered. Outside, the earlier downpour had left streaks on the windows.

“Red… Everything’s become more complicated. You, a former champion. Me, still just a **Gym** Leader. This discrepancy makes me feel hardened. Like Cinderella? I don’t know…”

“It was the other way round. You, an accomplished swimmer. Almost a local princess. Me, from a humble background. Without the Professor’s approval, our paths would never have crossed. The flood of your suitors… being with you is a burden. A burden not to make a show of it.”

The underestimation was laid bare. She took it as anything but a compliment.

“So everything between us must come to an end?”

“No. Our bond has forged certain rare qualities in you. Otherwise, you would have become arrogant…”

“Insolent…”

Resigned, almost. She went to the wardrobe. The note, on the table. From a distance, he read enough to blush. To vanish. To tear it up. Tact stopped him.

BGM ‘Always’ 00:00–00:30

“Is it replacing the photo…?”

“Not the content. Your hand. We can deduce your motives from it.”

“…I’m not much of a poet. But it represented my feelings at the time.

I anticipated the limits. I didn’t know any better. Damage. Serious. Sorry.”

Confessions. No more pretence. Misty explained:

“I do not speak for others. As far as I am concerned, you have nothing to fear.”

He struggled. Too simple, too broad. Misty continued:

‘A healthy sense of self: if I’d forced you to stay, it would have got worse. Perhaps we’d have broken up for good. A temporary separation is better than a break-up. That’s what I feared most.

I didn’t know your reasons. I’m sorry I couldn’t do anything about it. I’ve come to understand Blue’s burdens. The twists of fate. My badge wasn’t meant to bring you back…”

With a hint of sarcasm, refusing to yield, Red cut in:

“You’re wrong.”

“Enough of this consolation.”

A glint in the corners of his eyes—or the evening light. He did not make use of it.

“It’s true. I, too, feared what sort of person I would have become. An anti-hero. Cynicism. The arrogance of the victim. That wasn’t the case. Thanks to you.

The bond rests on the price paid, not just on the support. Staying isn’t always a good sign. You paid a moral price. So that I wouldn’t slip. Not because I was as pure as my Pikachu.

A flame needs water to prevent it from becoming a fire. With you at my side, I can face my weaknesses. Even now. Otherwise, I would have returned to the mountains.”

BGM ‘We Have Been Waiting’

The weight lifted awkwardly. She felt uncomfortable — these words of comfort were too heavy after years of silence.

Outside, Gold/Richter paused; something had slipped his mind. He turned back.

Misty said:

‘I voted for Green in the election.’

A look of astonishment spread across Red’s face. Misty continued:

‘I don’t know if my vote determined the outcome. He took on that role as a form of atonement. For your return. After his conversion, I realised you hadn’t neglected him out of carelessness. The choices were too difficult. I stood as guarantor. Otherwise, your sacrifice would have been foolish…’

A resigned smile. Fate had taken a turn without him, and yet for him. Misty asked:

“Who were you contacting?”

“The Professor. My mother, less often.”

“Why not me?”

“I wanted to. But I didn’t want you to see me at that stage… I was afraid of coming back too late. This reunion confirms that fear…

You’ve blossomed. Me, I’m much the same. My power has grown. My body, still that of a child. Power doesn’t protect the one I care about…”

The shyness returned, more physical than the prestige. A blush he’d been holding in since Mt. Silver. Misty teased:

“A boy has to protect his girl. Is that it…?”

‘…Girls need it. It’s a rule. It’s only natural that a boy would want to.’

‘You could be happy with someone else. You’re the one who shaped my foundations. That’s why I held on up there. I nearly let that chance slip away.’

She stepped closer. Her smile was playful, clear-eyed.

“It is a pleasure to see you, almost as you used to be. The nice lad with Charmander.

That weak little Pokémon seals our bonds before it evolves."

The word *'Charmander'* struck him like a knife. His doubts lingered still.

She took his hand. Moved it — a gesture of support, nothing more.
It was overwhelmed too quickly. Pull away. Insult. Her fingers were enough. Inside, he rebelled; recognised; channelled. He no longer rejected it. The contact remained austere. No audience. No badge.

"If you really were still a child, you'd be humiliating me. If you're more mature than you appear, you'll manage. I trust you.

You still have time to grow up slowly. I'll be there to witness it.'

The door. Gold/Richter, almost soundless. Surprise — a few seconds that felt too long. Then joy, clear, wordless. He walked away. He gave up on the object.

We did not see. We understood. He left them the room, and the twilight with it.

End of scene

Scene — The hostage in exchange

Cerulean — Misty's garden, 6–8 o'clock, autumn

The cool air still lingered. Misty had already left.

In the pond, Lapras and Lanturn. Golbat were flying off at odd angles, with no reason to fight. Houndoom was waiting for feeding time. Mt.Silver's two teams were no longer adversaries. Not a reconciliation — a misunderstanding cleared up, too late. The initiate had fallen. Even the camouflages of yesteryear were no longer there. Superfluous vigilance. A retrospective insight, somewhat naive.

Gold/Richter was not wearing his tailcoat; the heat was too much, too soon. No training. He was handing things out. A veteran who was too young. A serenity he had not felt in a long time.

Red stepped outside. The landscape was so peaceful it seemed almost fake.

Gold/Richter noticed him. A sober, natural smile. Red found it hard to believe this was the same man — the conqueror, with his extravagant methods.

As soon as he was close enough, Gold/Richter held out a slice. An invitation. Red took it.

'Are you feeling better now…?'

Houndoom approached, unhurriedly. Almost like a dog.

"That's a question best directed at you…"

Playful sarcasm. The half-patient tending to the almost intact body. A sense of unease in Red, with no malice in the other's eyes. Gold/Richter was curious:

"You've made up with Misty. That's all that matters, isn't it?"

“Yes… The problem is that things are getting better almost exclusively with her, you, even Apollo… Not the others.”

A sense of aversion in Red: being able to take on Apollo – a contradiction still fresh in his mind.

“A short trip. More reliable people to talk to… would be constructive. Let’s hope so.”

“Some would be only too happy to keep you company. You might consider exploring this place…”

Red’s eyes widened ever so slightly.

The rest went unheard.

BGM “EP01 S02 16:46–17:00”

“All right. Some sound advice.”

A hint of guilt flickered across Gold/Richter’s face.

“You’re setting off, and I’m staying with Misty… Is that really all right…?”

The deference. The bond. The concern. Red retorted:

“You’ll serve as a hostage…”

Gold/Richter lowered his eyelashes. Frowning. No longer a patient. A pledge.

The garden all around offered no comment. The Golbat were already too far away.

End of scene

Scene — The Alternate Pilot

New Bark — autumn morning, 8–9 am

Chirping. A banality already in place.

BGM ‘EP04 S02 18:10–19:00’

In the bedroom, Chris/Maria was dressed. All that remained were the comb and the green ribbon. Her fingers knew what to do. Experienced. Graceful without even thinking about it.

Then, in the garden, the Pokémon. Misdreavus, Venomoth, Noctowl. Too high-level for the innocuous, docile atmosphere. She poured the food into her palm. They came of their own accord. She watched them eat, generous, peaceful. There was no rush.

Then the water. The watering can, little by little. The flowers that had bloomed too much, the scissors. As the water reached the plants, her eyes clouded over for a moment — as if her soul were no longer quite there.

Her everyday life had been restored to her. A girl of her own age. Or perhaps the morning was merely pretending. That was enough to conceal the past, but not to erase it. A lingering languor in her movements. Time had not healed everything.

BGM ‘EP03 S01 16:54–17:29’

Not a chronic sorrow. A sense of deprivation. Someone. A necessary presence. She could live. Slightly incomplete. You could see it in her hands, in the way she held the scissors a little too tightly.

Misdreavus looked at her, almost childlike. It had read a part of it. It wasn't his fault — she hadn't captured it herself. She looked away to set him free.

Not pessimism. An anticipation. A mortgaged bliss. A promise to be kept. The deadline, indefinite.

The final stroke. A sharp sound.

—

On the way to Elm. The three of them levitating. Fresh leaves overhead. Neither hurried nor slow. Flat paths. The mud didn't stick. The strangeness of the journey had already faded.

BGM 'EP01 S02 08:00–08:16'

A wind that wasn't wind. Her attention sharpened.

Something came from the sky, without any unnecessary fluttering. When she turned, it was already on the ground. Skarmory.

A sense of déjà vu. But not yet certainty. She approached.

The bird seemed familiar. Gold/Richter's. She doubted it, then became almost certain.

BGM 'Fire It Is' 01:41–end

The pilot. The cloak. The reins. It was not Gold/Richter.

He dismounted. Put away his equipment. Turned round.

His face was clear. Red.

Chris/Maria's eyes widened in surprise. Nothing else, yet.

End of scene

Scene — Alternative Therapy

New Bark — Chris/Maria's house, 9–10 am

BGM: 'Don't Listen to Her' 00:00–01:04

The parents were at work. The living room, Western in style, understated and neat: light wood, few ornaments, nothing flashy.

Chris/Maria made the tea without rushing. She removed the tea bag in good time. The liquid remained clear. A tray of light sweets. She carried it all over. Misdreavus, Venomoth and Noctowl came and went, taking a breather.

She poured into Red's cup — slowly. Not a maid. A hostess.

The atmosphere was tense. He read her mood in her subtle gestures: no petulance, no accusation, no haughtiness. A discontent she refused to vent indiscriminately. He knew he was partly to blame. The contrast: her predecessor, her successor. He took a sip. As if the tea might ease the tension.

She sat down. Her mood did not lift.

‘Fortunately, my parents are at work for the time being…’

“Is my visit inconvenient…? Am I not welcome?”

“Yes. But the problem is…”

She poured herself a cup.

“He’d promised me he’d come back as soon as he’d brought you home. I saw you first. He wasn’t there…

The one riding Skarmory is not him either. What a humiliation…’

He had nothing to say in his defence. Nothing to absolve himself of. Chris/Maria asked:

“Where is he?”

“At Misty’s.”

Anger welled up, but she held it in. She understood the necessity. The situation remained absurd.

“He’s not in the best of shape. For having challenged me. Sorry for the trouble. It’s my fault.”

She didn’t know who to take it out on. She braked.

“…Don’t worry about it. But why borrow his Pokémon…?”

“To travel incognito. Charizard’s too rare. It’s practically my trademark. With him around, nothing would go unnoticed.”

“Right. I expected that sort of thing to come only from him. Even with you. It confuses me… your story or his…”

He struggled to find the right answer. She saw it, without fully understanding — she wasn’t *that important* to him. Red said:

“I’ve come… to find my place in the world again…”

“…Very well. What has earned me the privilege of your trust…?”

“Gold/Richter’s proposal. My trust in him. You wouldn’t reject me. He could see that.”

He added some sugar. He took a sip.

She had understood enough.

“So, shall we go out after tea…?”

She took another sip and a sweet.

—

Outside, the town opened out onto the countryside like a village nestled against the hillside, like a blend of Interlaken and Basel. A narrow canal between stone walls, rushing water, a patch of short

grass, railings. Wooden chalets, shutters, a bridge. Further on, a pale tower, a bell tower. Behind them, the mountain still too close, as if Mt.Silver hadn't quite taken his eyes off it. Flat paths. Leaves. Networks here that were connected to up there.

They walked.

Local figures waved to her. Then the guide. A stranger. Not the age they would have expected to see by her side. Curiosity, without malice. They linked the profession to the legend. The greeting grew more restrained. A latent gratitude. Red returned the handshake. They went back to their daily lives. He watched them until they disappeared from view. A simple kindness. She, as if this were the usual sight. Red remarked:

'So my decision was reciprocated…'

"Not all of them. But it's not our custom to deify the prominent."

He gazed intently.

"…These landscapes, Johto… I used to look at them every day. From up high. This is the first time I've come down to see them up close…"

"It's the other way round for us. Gazing upon Mt. Silver is almost a privilege. You and him… truly enviable."

The sarcasm laid bare his own limitations. He didn't object.

"New Bark… as beautiful, austere and peaceful as my own."

"I do not appreciate Kanto quite as much. Yours suggests that a place is reserved for you there. Thanks to you, presumably."

"And yours welcomes me as if I were born there. Whereas I am in no state to return to my own…"

They made their way back to the market. Stalls. Timber. The smell of piped water. Chris/Maria asked:

"On this occasion… are you going to travel elsewhere in our homeland…?"

"I would like to. But not under these circumstances.

Apart from Misty, Gold/Richter and you, I haven't grown accustomed to the others yet. I will savour Johto once I have recovered enough. For better experiences with the locals. Here first. Then Kanto. My town."

A more pleasant smile on her face. On his, no embarrassment: just curiosity. Chris/Maria asked:

'I thought you were different. You're quite alike. Thoughtful. Resourceful. Even a bit clumsy.'

"Sorry. It's almost second nature to us…"

"I was teasing him about it. As if he had a monopoly on it, and you were excluded. That clumsiness catches on with a lot of people. In your line of work, with your tasks… it's almost an inevitable symptom – neither an identity nor a definitive cure."
She continued:

"Tell me. How did he pull it off? Was he simply that skilled, or did he cheat…?"

The delight was plain to see in Red's eyes.

“…Neither. I lost the debate rather than the fight…”

A blush crept up on Red’s cheeks. Chris/Maria could tell:

“…You’re right. He’s not really a warrior like you… despite the compensations.”

“That is why I was able to come down. He makes up for what is beyond my abilities. Otherwise, I would have grown old in the mountains…”

“Insightful. Inspector. Doctor. That prodigious talent makes him vulnerable. More so than Green, at times. Without a childhood friend, he’d never have made it…”

He smiled. All right.

“I apologise for the sarcasm you must endure to remain with us. For Misty’s sake. And especially for yours…”

BGM ‘My Sister’ 00:00–00:30

“Misty would have needed it if she’d had to put up with a Pokédex like me. Luckily, she’s only a Gym Leader…”

“Ho-Oh and Lugia sent him to find me. Should we consider him the Chosen One? Hard to imagine, given the circumstances…”

“…According to their emissaries, the issue isn’t whether one is chosen. It’s whether one stands with them. Pure hands, perfection… neither you nor him. If they were, we’d have to accept our duties — and that they aren’t always clean, in certain circumstances.”

“So which version do you believe?”

“I’m leaning towards the idea that you aren’t the Chosen Ones. That deprives us of less. Less unnecessary loneliness. Misty wouldn’t want this distance between you if you really were…”

He found it slightly amusing. Not being the Chosen One: a closeness that remained possible. The canal, nearby, flowed on. Nothing there gave way to speeches.

End of scene

Scene — Bureaucratic Felicity

New Bark — Elm’s laboratory, 10–12 o’clock

BGM ‘EP01 S01 14:37–16:34’

There was something bureaucratic about the atmosphere. Almost like a filing cabinet. Elm took a sip of coffee.

They were already settled in. On the table lay printed announcements — those from Gold/Richter. Red was poring over them, stunned less by the meticulousness than by the language: too formal. A tacit harmony with that office gossip.

Gold/Richter, on screen, on call. His habit of teasing had not returned — certainly not towards Red. He looked as though he had suffered from having seen certain things too soon, before leaving.

Elm and Red exchanged a furtive glance. That paradoxical relationship amused them in spite of themselves.

‘Welcome to police headquarters. To the investigations department,’ she said.

Chris/Maria turned towards the monitor.

“So you’re being held hostage by Misty. Or used as collateral…?”

An awkward remark. Not pathetic. Ill-suited to a retort. Gold/Richter implored Red.

“Red, please.”

“It’s so that Green and Professor Oak don’t find out. So he can’t settle anywhere else. Only there…”

She softened her tone. She’d guessed part of the reason.

“Very well. With them it would be more complicated. We would need better terms. And you, well.

By any chance, was Red really your toughest opponent…?”

The shifty eyes. The mockery. Gold/Richter thought for a moment.

“He was… the strongest. Not the worst…”

The concentration deepened, over there, behind the screen. Chris/Maria teased.

“Very well. Not the worst. That spared him from having to fight you himself. I bet…”

Gold/Richter did not argue; he merely shifted the topic, lest he linger too long upon that truth. Red defended him.

“Spare him. His methods were ambiguous. They spared him the whip. And spared me from seeing him struggle against my Pokémon…”

The redness, on the other hand, deepened. Injustice. Playful revenge. Elm revelled in his cup. Gold/Richter pleaded.

‘Sorry I’m late, Chris/Maria.’

Chris/Maria replied calmly.

“We do miss you, though.”

Caustic tenderness. Quite warm. Gold/Richter took it in his stride. Red said.

“Here, everything is more bureaucratic. More administrative. Less government-like than at Professor Oak’s. It brings a sense of calm. A sense of camaraderie. Whereas his contributions are unusual. More irreplaceable than ours. Enviable.”

The compliment came across the wrong way, as it often did. Professor Elm asked.

“Are you off now, Red?”

“Yes.”

“Well then, I have something for you.”

Professor Elm had already gone off to fetch it.

‘Is it for the Pokédex…?’

“From me, for you, in terms of the Pokédex? No need.”

The item. A Poké Gear. Professor Elm said.

“You’re aiming to get back to normal life. It’s not just about talking. Staying in touch. Isn’t that right?”

Red’s face lit up; this was precisely what he had wanted. He was delighted. Not a second Pokédex. A connection.

End of scene

Scene — The role of Gym Leaders

Cinnabar — autumn twilight

The waves took their time. The ruins were still smouldering. No flames: just low, grey smoke, in places like puffs of breath. The ground remained warm beneath his feet. The air smelled of warm sulphur and damp ash.

BGM ‘Annette’s Journey’ 00:00–00:55

They were already walking. Red had adjusted to Blaine’s pace. The walking stick was no burden; it brought relief. The slower pace held. Blaine could see, on Red’s face, the effect this change was having.

‘If these landscapes distress you so much, why are you here?’

Red followed.

“…I didn’t get the right information. I’d heard about the casino, the fence, the pollution… This one had slipped my mind… Though it’s not the worst of it…”

He looked at the ruins. A sense of warmth. Horrors still possible, from a distance.

“Green felt the same way,” said Blaine. “When it was his turn to keep me company here.

Shortly afterwards, your successor followed in his footsteps, in my presence…”

Red dozed off. Then a look of perplexity, almost providential. Blaine said:

“I doubted whether I’d assigned my badge to him correctly. I was glad that impression turned out to be wrong. Raising a child… an inalienable process. From time to time.”

‘Did it work for me too…?’

“I’ve never regretted it. Your passion was already heading in the right direction. After Team Rocket, it had already reached its full potential. I gave you back what was already a part of you.”

— 00:40–00:55 + coda

‘Thank you. And the boy? Is there a blue flame within him too?’

“…People claimed to see it. Deceptive. A hope projected onto the new generation. The flame doesn’t really conform to its nature.”

“…It would seem so.”

Red pondered. He adjusted his form.

‘Thank you for your company. It’s time. Everything is irreversible. You don’t stay a trainer simply out of complacency. That lad brought me down. Not to remind me that fighting is a joy. He admitted it himself.’

A major omission, almost irreparable. Blaine suggested:

‘In that case, you’re welcome to visit my Gym.’

“What do you mean? Isn’t it too late? The rift between us…”

Too much. Guilt flashed in his eyes. Blaine added:

“I’m not inviting you because I could defeat you…”

The man in glasses bowed his head ever so slightly.

“I am a scientist. Less busy than Oak. I am in charge of the Flame type. It gives me a sense of purpose to help the younger generation, to connect with them. My heart is no longer at your age. I still serve to remind people of the joy of being Trainers.

Battle transforms knowledge into strength. Strength enables us to protect, to bond, to take responsibility. I do not uphold tradition like Pryce. A reason to live is enough. That is the role of a Gym Leader. Is it not?”

Red was satisfied. The offer still stood.

At dusk the waves continued to crash against the shore. No amount of talking would change that.

End of scene

Scene — Fellow citizen or stranger

Celadon — autumn twilight

The flat felt both too much like his own and not enough. His parents were away. Eusine wasn’t wearing the full suit: jacket, bow tie, shirt, cufflinks. At the table, a sip of tea. The unease wasn’t one of disgust. A dissonance. The strangeness of being *here*.

The last drop, with a wobble that was still elegant. He got dressed. Gloves. The white coat. He went out to clear his head.

Outside, the routes offered no relief. They merely provided a breath of fresh air.

BGM ‘EP02 S02 11:21–11:35’

A public fountain. A boy sitting there. His gaze said: he is waiting. All too clear — his existence, his arrival, his gentle expression. Eusine recognised him. He couldn't take it all in at once. It took him a while.

Further on, a bench, set slightly apart.

BGM "EP04 S01 22:40–24:12"

"Gold/Richter let me know that someone would be keen to speak with me. I wasn't expecting someone like this," said Eusine.

"It's so as not to cause too much trouble. Especially as my route hadn't been clearly agreed…

Do you come back… regularly?"

"Out of parental duty. Once a year. And why me?"

"Your reputation. And because you are a more manageable compatriot to approach, to begin with…"

"I'm not quite seen as a fellow countryman. Not quite a foreigner either…"

Red smiled.

"How's life as an expat? Or the quest…?"

"Learning about cultures and languages isn't a benefit in itself. It can lead one astray. Make one stop in one's tracks. Indoctrinate. Allow one to escape. We invent representations, we mould them into culture, into a backdrop, into credibility — not for the future. For the past. Almost exclusively for those who came before us. We stifle what is to come. A cult. We leave our own behind, we switch to the other's."

'That resonates with the approach of the one I had to stand up to…'

A sense of listlessness in Red. Melancholy. Satiation with the past. Someone's dazed state, lamented without a name.

"What motivated you to undertake this journey?"

"Firstly, the beauty of a legend. Then, my understanding matured. Some forms of beauty are alluring, authentic, yet immanent. Others are contrived. The kind that entices, almost gratuitously, hollow at its core, stirs up idolatry — not wisdom. Suicune's beauty stems from a bond, a debt of gratitude. Like the feats of heroes: alienation, self-denial, sacrifice."

Red grasped a part of it.

'Are you less yourself there…?'

"In principle, yes. In retrospect, only partly.

The return is not a complete waste. My people have, on the whole, conformed. Those who did not follow have become exceptions — performative, identity-driven. To rebel: a haughty detachment, excess, bottomless sedition, victimisation. I ended up benefiting from this opportunity. Johto is not a utopia. It offers healthier points of reference.

I'd been led to believe that, to preserve, one had to be a poet, a torrent of verse, an artistic eccentric. My career is the opposite. I infuse it with poetry. I apply it with consistency. Research. Lectures."

“The modern admonition…?”

“The living debt.”

Red’s attention froze for a moment. Eusine continued:

BGM “Don’t Leave Me” 00:00–02:00

‘Freedom, rights… are debts. We are entitled to them. Certainly. But they are not a given. Without the pioneers, without intercession, they would have remained out of reach. To bestow them without upholding them, without fighting for them, without remembering them, is to reduce them to mere status symbols, badges, and the arrogance of privilege. The syndrome of our age. Why Kanto has become this way.”

‘So, should we abandon everything here…?’

“Elsewhere has blossomed from its roots. It cannot make up for everything. Over there, we have long since paid our dues. Elsewhere, we would pay a higher price, sometimes never enough. Drawing upon it with purpose spares us part of that process. I believe.”

Red took it in, conciliatory.

“I’d also come to thank you for looking after Gold/Richter. And to learn about him from a third party.”

Eusine’s mind was intrigued.

“…At first glance, phenomenal for his age. Intelligent. Perceptive. As for modesty, that remains to be seen.”

“Is modesty harmful in itself…?”

“It depends on the sort. The world reduces everything to arrogance or modesty. The balanced sort allows one to come to terms with fatigue and pain. The venomous sort rejects glorification, belittles, conceals one’s worth — for the sake of order and politeness. On reflection, he’s done rather well. More than just a successor. In my estimation.”

“Oh. Who, then?”

“From the moment we met him, we took him for your younger brother. Devoted…”

A vague flush. Eusine retorted:

“Succeeding you weighed heavily on him. A sense of inferiority in the face of your exploits. Even at the cost of hurting the one he loves. He shouldered almost everything. Sharing your burdens. Preserving a prestige, a reputation that was almost a family legacy. He treated you as flesh and flaws, without remorse. Without knowing whether he would be treated the same way — before the journey. Unlikely, unless he took this post for the sake of a family connection.”

“That seems a heavy burden. He is not my brother of blood. I fear he may have devoted himself too much. Overburdened…”

Red shifted uneasily. Eusine explained:

“I cannot answer for him. There are few clues. I do not judge whether it is frenzied, one-sided, or obsessive. He is imperfect. He has succeeded in his tasks, and tempered that modesty. Without a

measure of balanced gratitude, it would not have been achieved. That is what prevails. Grasp this connection."

Red needed time.

They made their way to the centre. Some locals vaguely recognised his face. They'd passed each other too quickly: doubt lingered, unresolved. Eusine's presence helped ease it. Red paid even less attention to the chance glances.

Near the sewers, a foul stench. Muk, Grimer, in the pipes. Eusine held his coat close to shield himself from the stench.

"Sorry about this depravity in Kanto."

"You're mistaken. It's been improved. Slowly. Still insignificant, though.

Not everyone here was wicked. But relieving my burden too much would have sapped their courage. I had to fight almost alone…

After all those years, someone from Kanto saved my successor. Not a proper Trainer. Bold. Responsible. A break from the past. Without her, he would not have survived, would not have found his freedom, would not have returned. That matters. Even if you are not from Kanto in the usual sense. At least not by learning, or perhaps through conversion."

A subdued smile. A nod.

Further on, some Murkrow. Feathers. Neutral, detached, somewhat vacant gazes.

Red could not quite suppress his fear. Eusine noticed it. He did not ask about it straight away.

"The day I decided to leave, I'd seen them. And their master, through them. A primal evil."

Eusine's eyes, a little glum. Not fearful.

"Has that fear been overcome…?"

Red showed something else — warmer, clearer.

"No. The fear remains. I am no longer without support in the face of it. I no longer have to face it alone."

Eusine turned fully towards him. He was glad of it.

The birds remained neutral, with a touch of mischief. The consternation, however, was no longer the same.

End of scene

Scene — The Mutation Contrary to Appearances

Celadon — twilight

BGM 'Don't Leave Me' 02:00–the rest

The centre still held. On a public bench, the Gentleman of yesteryear. The walking stick. Growlithe, still in its pre-evolved form. Almost nothing about them had changed. The years seemed to have passed in vain. Appearances could be deceiving.

He allowed himself this tranquillity. A small, understated bliss, like a philosophy that needs no words. He stroked the dog. Growlithe accepted it, contentedly.

Then came the reunion. In the dim light, he recognised him. No fuss. A quiet welcome.

Red.

He sat down at the other end. He released Pikachu, without a word. The scene from long ago, almost too familiar — as if to show that the setting had not changed.

Pikachu approached Growlithe. A measured sense of intimacy. No pretence. Neither's status created a barrier. The gentleman began:

'You haven't changed much over the years…'

"Outwardly, yes. The same goes for you…"

"Often we share more when we've changed a great deal on the outside. Sometimes it's the other way round. Appearances remain almost the same. The inside, barely visible. Waiting to be discovered. It makes one want to have a chat…"

Red did not reply straight away; he was getting ready. What followed was no longer for those watching.

Kanto Mountains — day

Arid. Inaccessible. Largely barren. Not a single precipice. Still, you had to be careful.

The Hiker made his way with Diglett. A pastime that remained a labour. The wooden staff. Panting, after the climb.

A flash in the sky. Metal. Its outline lost in the glare. The creature charged, then deliberately slowed down. The Hiker realised: the trajectory was meant for him.

The reflection descended. Red. Skarmory.

The ground here offered no place to land. Red did not press the matter.

He raised his hand. Affable. A gratitude from days gone by, still there. The Hiker returned the gesture. Forbearance. Nothing more.

Skarmory slowed without lingering — just long enough for their eyes to meet. Then it flew over the man and the Pokémon. No looking back.

An austere contentment. Rare. The bird resumed its journey. The sky, behind it, offered no comment.

End of scene

Scene — The Invigorating Succession

, Cerulean — Gold/Richter's room, dusk

Light was already fading in the room, which was far too small. The screen still illuminated his face. One of the Kimono Girls. Gold/Richter had straightened up since Red had left — his shoulder less hunched, his cane within reach, more in the foreground. The Kimono Girl congratulated him:

'Your achievements are ahead of you.'

Sober. A restrained joy. On his part, a touch of awkwardness: no desire to fade into the background. The desire not to turn this into a headline. Gold/Richter replied:

"Thank you. Sorry I have to stay a little longer. Some loose ends to tie up. Reluctant to waste the grant."

BGM "EP07 S01 09:50–10:35"

"Feel free," she consoled him.

"Presumably… you could suggest some new themes to us. Or guidelines…"

He was thinking too fast. Possibilities were flooding in; his hands didn't know where to start.

"You're already practising it quite authentically, aren't you…?" he asked.

"Your experiences would be a rare commodity. To prevent rigidity."

A silence. He laid out the words as one lays out tools:

"…Agreed. No praise. No badges. Illustrating the treachery of evil. The corresponding virtues. How to repress it. Reminding people of the cost. How fragile peace is. In my view.

The rest, when I return. Agreed?"

"It's agreed."

The screen went dark. He exhaled—at length. A respite he hadn't taken since Apollo.

As he turned, Red was already in the frame. He'd been waiting. Skarmory's ball, in his palm, still warm from the journey. Gold/Richter read between the lines: the journey over, the body not yet returned.

"Has your journey come to an end?" asked Gold/Richter, his curiosity piqued.

"Yes. It's impossible to go back to the way things were…"

The sentence fell without pathos. A statement of fact. Gold/Richter nodded, as one acknowledges the changing of the seasons:

"That's typical. Readjusting. Settling in. Even if imperfectly. What's new?"

"The information about you."

A deep flush rose to his cheeks. Eusine. He hadn't expected to be *read* that way. Red put him at ease:

'You can trust me. You've done well. A measured modesty. And given what you've been through.'

No teasing. A truth all too clear. Gold/Richter took it as a dig — in spite of himself. He turned away towards the drawer, too quickly.

The leveller. Small. Inconspicuous. Red didn't immediately see why. Gold/Richter realised:

BGM "EP06 S01 09:00–09:58"

"You must have had to pull out the Pokédex for the tough enemies. I ordered that. So as not to reveal my identity."

Skarmory's level appeared on the screen. Red stopped in his tracks. A sense of wonder washed over him, leaving him defenceless.

"You're brilliant. So thoughtful. Even more so than I am…?"

Gold/Richter shook his head. Almost too soon.

"Not true. Without you, I'd never have anticipated this need. You've helped me avoid so many mistakes — the ones I kept repeating. In your place, you'd have considered the same outcomes."

"Not everyone is cut out for it," said Red.

"…I do not reject the prodigy. I developed what I excelled at — under your protection. A talent needs soil that is secure enough. I cannot deny that. Your kindness came at a cost. To claim I am superior to you… I cannot bring myself to do it."

The sorrow he felt now was not feigned humility. It was the very impossibility of pride. Red consoled him:

"So you haven't lost your way."

Gold/Richter looked down at the floor. His shoulder slumped slightly.

'…Red. I've thought a great deal about our successes. You subdued Rocket, Green — not because you were the strongest. Our paths have crossed. I wasn't the strongest either. They didn't measure it precisely. Blind spot. Our weaknesses aren't absolute flaws. Embracing them unlocks potential — barely foreseeable to them, or to us. Evil has its own. Ours, amongst those who believe themselves to be good, are more serious. Unless, that is, one accepts the price. Evil is not omnipotent. The good are not entirely naive. It's simply that evil can channel the cost more easily."

Red took this as a question he had already asked himself.

"Do you mean that we've simply accepted the consequences…?"

"…Yes. We're clear-headed enough. But not all-powerful. Others, far more capable, are hesitating, whilst we've accepted the price. I've decided to fight Houndoom. Apollo has been held back. We wouldn't be able to do it the same way again, from now on."

"So what are we to do now?"

"Train the new fighters."

The words cut the air. No mere Gym tactic. Gold/Richter revealed:

BGM 'Too Heavy'

"Apollo sees further. It is not intellect that determines evil. It is moral decision-making. He committed too soon. Too late for atonement. The true enemies are neither Team Rocket, nor Giovanni, nor Apollo. But the breakdown of the ethical lineage."

“So, my decision wasn’t meant to be a lesson…?”

The fear, underlying the statement: that Mt. Silver had served no purpose. Gold/Richter recounted:

“Yes. For Lance, Green, and me. Too specific. Not clear enough. The cost is too one-sided. It bought us time. Misty managed to hold you off. It wasn’t enough to generate media coverage.”

He sat down on the edge of the bed. Gold/Richter’s voice changed:

‘For the Old Man Coyote, extinguishing my courage would suffice. Even if I were to overcome it, simply preventing myself from using it rightly would be enough. Warriors remove oppression. Ethics prevent it from returning. Just as my use of grey methods does, without completely corrupting me. Moreover, I believed that love and friendship were more vulnerable. I was wrong. The qualities that ward off evil — modesty, perseverance, loyalty, patience, gratitude, courage, compassion — but if they stray even slightly, or become tainted by the seven deadly sins, the result would be devastating… the Old Man Coyote doesn’t even need to dismantle them.”

Red slowly put into words what he already understood.

“So we must remember the cost. Just how fragile peace is…?”

“…Yes. Without glorification. Without a badge. Johto isn’t perfect. More people there share the burden. I haven’t been crushed to the same extent as you. We don’t replace your visceral connection. We can still interpret your experiences. Complement you.”

“Sorry it’s not so easy to replace…”

“…Indeed. I’m more certain of that now. After Silver. After Apollo, too.”

Red blinked. The certainty, after Apollo, was not what he had anticipated. Gold/Richter continued:

“Evil requires lucidity. That has consequences. Cruel wisdom. Apollo didn’t escape it. His prodigy forged a bond with him—not through blood: through experience. The incompleteness of his cruelty. Not exploitable in the way he abuses ours. For this to work, we need our integrity.

The Old Man Coyote is an usurper. Not the Creator. He knows our uses. Not love. Nor the potential of succession. Misty, you, Lance, even me. I survived. You cannot eradicate the shadow. But that is no excuse for us to resign ourselves to it. We tame it; we do not let it put us in our place. Like the recurring winters.”

A moment’s pause. A blank expression on his face—something Gold/Richter still didn’t know how to convey:

“That visceral bond… I don’t know how to make up for it. The one between you and Misty. Chris/Maria and me. Not blood. But fragile. Precious. Indispensable.”

Red listened to him right to the end. Incomplete. Enough. Contentment came without a broad smile.

“Still, I’m glad to have a successor like you.”

They embraced. Briefly. Imperfectly. Incompletely. Cherished — with its price, its scarcity. Outside, the twilight had not shifted. Inside, something had settled.

End of scene

Scene — The Reason for Returning

Cerulean — same room, a moment later

The embrace had broken. Gold/Richter asked:

'By the way, Silver would like to see you. No doubt.'

Red nodded, awkwardly. Vile fragments of Giovanni flashed through his mind. His aversion to his father was distinct. Neither joy nor reluctance.

Gold/Richter tapped. The call went through. Answered.

BGM 'Being Dracula's Son' 00:26–the end

Silver. Unprepared. He regretted it — too late to pull himself together, not a rejection. The grudge against Red hadn't been swept away. Dusty. Not polished. It was obvious. It exacerbated everything.

Red sensed it. A steady unease. He took the initiative — seniority. His gaze, intense, fixed on the monitor.

'I'm just glad to see you in such good shape…'

Silver heard it amid the confusion. He sat up straight. He gave up trying to adjust his posture. A faint sense of calm.

Gold/Richter and Red exchanged glances. A rare step forward.

Then Silver's voice, urgent.

"My apologies. The reason for the call… I'm currently tracking Giovanni…"

Surprise on both sides. Gold/Richter tried to clarify:

"Have you located him…?"

"Yes. Our paths cross over the course of several days. To take him on head-on…"

He was channelling. It was obvious. Gold/Richter grew concerned:

"…Aren't you willing enough to do that…?"

"Certainly not. At the radio tower, I wasn't up to the task. I went there anyway. So that Johto wouldn't be in vain. That option is no longer a possibility."

Gold/Richter felt compassion. Not the right words — not an equal at that age, not that father. The sentences got stuck.

"I'm sorry my methods aren't up to scratch when it comes to a moving target…"

Silver did not ask him to feign understanding:

"Earlier, I didn't have much to lose. My actions were reckless. Now, I have more to lose. It weighs heavier. How funny."

A sarcastic remark, to take the edge off. Red cuts in:

“That’s only natural.”

They both jumped. Red had made his decision.

BGM “EP08 S02 14:15 14:38”

“You’re not treating him like your father. Nor are you taking it lightly. You’re simply facing up to it.

One reason this boy defeated me: he wanted to return to someone dear to him. If you desire that, and you handle that desire well, you’ll succeed. You’ll come back.

I believe you’ll succeed with dignity. And that you’ll return to your chosen family.”

Silver was satisfied with that. The worry remained. She didn’t have to leave for the statement to hold true. For a moment, the screen asked for nothing more.

End of scene

Scene — You Wouldn’t Regret It

League — Lance’s office, then the hall, twilight

The documents were filed away. No chaos. Just a pile that was a little too high. Lance signed with an ease that was no longer merely procedural. Human. A respite, requested. Then the message — a casual visit, confirmed too quickly. A slight suspicion. He thanked them and left.

The room was already sheltering them. Bruno, Koga, Will, Karin. A sober, genuine, slightly languid delight — like people who had been waiting without admitting it.

Two figures. One, Lance recognised by his outfit, without seeing his face. The other required a moment’s thought, his forehead. They turned round.

Gold/Richter. Red. Benign.

Lance had not dared to hope for this outcome, even if he had wanted it. He did not quite believe he deserved it. Gratitude came all the same. Silent. Resigned. He took the fruit.

Red scanned the room. The faces. A curious delight.

‘You’d assured me I wouldn’t regret leaving. In hindsight, it was for the best. It brought in the old-timers, the newcomers, the promoted ones…’

Lance’s smile spoke volumes.

“Without such an inspiring predecessor, I’d never have made the most of what I had to begin with. I’m delighted you have no regrets.”

While they were still talking, Gold/Richter approached Karin almost silently. Houndoom’s Poké Ball. She took it. A sense of languor. She looked at it for a long time, saying nothing. Gold/Richter expressed his gratitude:

“Thank you. Without your Pokémon, I would have lost by now. No doubt.”

Unashamedly. The limits, accepted. Karin asked:

“Have you managed to master that power…?”

He nodded. Karin agreed:

“It is the best option. To face the trauma. Not to carry it around with you all the time. You can let it go now…”

She turned to Red.

“Incidentally, if my pupil has defeated you with my Pokémon… do I get a share of that victory? Or have I also defeated you…?”

It was half a tease. Red sensed the calculated irony. Karin continued:

BGM “EP01 S02 04:30–05:40”

“I’m just teasing. It suggests that neither he nor you fought alone. That’s why he didn’t defeat you as the strongest. No one succeeded. The imprecation is no longer directed at anyone…”

Gold/Richter’s astonishment was palpable:

“You anticipated that as well…?”

‘That lies beyond my foresight. A fortunate outcome. Coincidental. No…

If Lance had never taken over, I would never have contributed to it. Lance is probably not the strongest. The best champion, in our eyes…’

Lance accepted the praise. Paradoxical. Sincere. The others agreed, without saying so.

Will spoke up, gently.

“By the way, did you make the most of your trip…?”

Gold/Richter remembered Kanto. That unpleasant experience.

‘Not exactly. Rather unpleasant. Thanks to your wisdom, I made the most of it. It wasn’t in vain. I was able to incorporate what was disagreeable — and what built me up.’

Will stroked his chin. A smile. A silent nod of approval.

Red turned to Gold/Richter, then to Koga.

BGM “Part of the Same Story” 00:00–01:07

“Your methods were controversial. Yet quite moderate. Is that perhaps partly to your credit, Koga…?”

Sceptical praise. Koga replied:

“Not quite. Some young people already stand out because of their talent. But if adults set high enough examples in their own fields, it’s reassuring. They feel less alone. Less helpless.”

Bruno rested his hands on his knees.

“That resonates with perseverance. Discipline. They enable us to overcome thorny challenges. They already underpin everyday life. Discreetly. Almost imperceptibly. First, you have to see them — face, body, flesh — to make them understandable. Then recognise them within. Duration alone is not enough. If they conceal the cost, or chase after glory, they divert from the goal. They then serve the wrong ends.”

Gold/Richter started at the onslaught.

‘Why didn’t you mention this to me before…?’

A fear of offending was in his tone.

“When you were here, you were already demonstrating your qualities. The balance was there. A part of it… too soon, then. Koga’s wisdom was enough. Silence is not wise in itself. It can pass for a flaw. I, for my part, use it to read.”

A smile flitted across the room. Awkward. It was accepted. The eccentricity held true. No one needed anything more.

End of scene

Scene — Not that era, but perhaps now

, Viridian — a hall, then a bench, an autumn day

The room was neat, understated, functional. Small enough for the theme to work. Little inclination to take a real interest in it. Green spoke without enthusiasm about the parade. A pragmatic driving force. Sustainability, already, in the rhythm.

BGM ‘EP05 S01 18:34–19:24’

In the thick of it, he spotted the figure. Through the window. Her movements suggested she’d been there for a while. The audience sensed his surprise. He contained it. Professional integrity. His composure returned. Holding out until the end became a challenge. He held on.

—

Outside, further away. A little-trodden path. Charizard. Blastoise. Already outside. A subtle distance. No more hostility. The past, however, had not been erased. That was enough to make him stagger, to take a step back. They were trying all the same. A residual intimacy, to be mended. Not without a hitch.

Red and Green sat down. The bench did little to break the ice. It was not awkwardness: it was the anticipation of a breakthrough. Red began:

‘I didn’t expect you to be any good at this. Not even with an excessive passion…’

“I prioritise longevity. Enduring love over the initial spark. At this rate, I’m devoting myself to it.”

“And childcare…?”

“I’m past that age. Not a veteran at it either. I’ll leave the honour to others. Children see science in their own way.”

The frankness sparked a brief, sharp burst of joy in Red.

“I was wondering about the reason. An unusual role for you,” said Red.

“To show you the reforms. Here. The worst place, before. You can’t fix everything in Kanto. From here, it’s possible. An approach other than brute force. To prove you were right: you’d been shielded by a monopoly, by a technocracy — by a momentary lapse of judgement.”

The troubles of that time seemed to fade into the past. Not erased.

BGM ‘EP03 S02 25:00–26:30’

“It is strange. You, Gold/Richter… you seem surrounded by women, by elders. Few male peers. No guarantee. You have managed to get by. It prevents you from aiming for supreme power. And certain follies.”

“You too. Apart from Blue, I don’t remember so many peers.”

“Yes. For a stupid reason. A decisive one. The result… a mixed bag. Devastating.”

Red caught the allusion.

“If you’d been surrounded by boys, no one would have been able to hold you back. To set you straight…”

A bitter smile. Yet, a sense of delight nonetheless. Red elaborated:

“…I’d always wanted to tell you. My standards were sky-high. I’d have liked to have been more lenient. I couldn’t think of anything better…”

His voice had dropped. As if he were accepting the blame.

Green read between the lines. He accepted the leniency.

“No. You were right.

Privilege blinded me. Not just towards others. You included. I thought you were inferior — despite the hard work, the extra effort. It might well have been the case. I overlooked your circumstances. Fewer resources. Less stability. How blind I was. I reduced your achievements to a mere prodigy. I had only myself to blame. Optimisation is not the same as existential development.”

“Did it take you a while…?”

‘Not after the League. After you’ve gone.

We inflict wounds. Dealing with them: remorse, often an escape, a quest for mercy. We look after ourselves. But seeing others force themselves — becoming cold, cruel in spite of themselves — to make amends for our faults: that’s more visceral. Too costly. Watching a debt I could never have repaid, paid by others… too much to bear. I could not bear it.”

Caustic melancholy. Red was not entirely immune to it. Green added:

‘You can see for yourself, at the League, what you’d become. The look in your eyes. The temperament. The tactics. Things you’d never have adopted. That apparent coldness. As if I were seeing what I’d have become — and wouldn’t have been able to change. Even that sentence: that you couldn’t bring yourself to say you regarded me as a brother.’

“I realised it later. Professor Oak wanted to save me that way. Despite certain limitations. I couldn’t have done it that way. It would have made me too conventional.”

BGM “EP05 S02 03:10–04:00”

"…Yes. You were right. I got past Giovanni's team, thanks to my starter. But you don't just change your fate on a whim."

"I thought I hated you."

Green did not deny it. Red continued:

"I didn't manage it."

Astonishment. A duality: redemption, or defiance. He did not know yet. Whilst Red explained:

'You could have chased the mirage. Hurt the one you loved. Avoided facing the risk of losing everything, the damage too severe. You could have put it on hold, numbed yourself — but no further. You aren't naturally that cruel. That's why I felt indebted to you.'

"…You're too selfless."

"…I didn't avoid causing harm. Sins. Temptations. Not self-sacrifice. It was worth it for someone who could take responsibility to undertake it."

"I headed for the radio tower. For Team Rocket."

Red looked surprised. Green continued:

"I had a premonition that you'd intervene. I kept watch. To spare you that trouble. Yet strength alone is no longer so versatile. I was mistaken. I sensed your frustration on the throne. Hollow. Formless."

"You've learnt. It took time. A price."

A silence breaks. Red spoke:

'…To be honest. The conflict between our starters still weighs on me. Not the pride. The trainers. The partners. Despite you, I haven't quite recovered. It's a heavy burden.'

Green did not object. A smile. He took out a badge. Green. As if he had kept it for this.

Red's surprise.

"I took on this role for that reason too," said Green. "In the hope that three years will be enough to make up for Giovanni's shortcomings.

You've set his aside. You can do without it. You don't need to command obedience. But if it proves you haven't defeated a champion obsessed with strength — a Gym Leader — it will come back to you. Like a worthy Trainer. So that you can let go of the old one."

He held it out. Red took it. Slowly. Without hesitation. A sense of contentment, as if *this* was finally the right badge.

BGM 'Greatwords' 02:59–end

"Red. I'm not used to feeling inferior. You were right to choose Charmander."

The admission unnerved him; it boded well. Red had never coveted it. Green admitted:

"I have to admit… you were gallant with Charizard. At Silph.co. Facing Team Rocket."

Red smiled. Humbly. A brief compliment.

"Green… I said I couldn't. Back then, anyway. Now, perhaps."

Green agreed. He did not press the matter further. He was content with that. On the bench, the two Pokémon had not moved a single step closer. Nor had they moved any further back.

End of scene

Scene — The Third Soul

, Viridian — Green's home, an autumn day

The house was simple, designed for two. Yellow petals floated in the cold air, clinging for a moment to the steps before drifting on. The scent was that of a garden already somewhat bare.

Blue was sitting outside, a cup of black tea in her hands. She was staring straight ahead without really seeing anything. A languor had taken hold of her, too mature for her age — as if a marriage had already taken place, without ceremony, and all that remained was to hold the cup. She raised the liquid to her lips to stave off the feeling that was growing heavier.

Three figures appeared at the end of the path. Two of them were recognisable even from a distance. The third required a closer look.

At first, a rush of euphoria swept through her — they had come together. Then a chronic, visceral unease took her breath away. It tempered the all too rare joy. The boys noticed the change. Not the fundamentals. Red noted the maturity of her body. The bond with Misty held; he did not succumb. That did not disappoint her. It lifted a weight from her.

She welcomed them as usual.

'Welcome back.'

Almost a formality. A cover-up.

Red halted a pace too soon. He searched for the right words, then blurted out:

'Am I really welcome?'

"Yes."

Green frowned slightly.

"Why such an accusatory tone…?"

Blue set down her cup. The clatter was faint. Faint enough to silence them.

"I'm glad you've come back," she said. "But that also means I have to face the past. And everything that gets complicated because of you. I can't cope…"

Red then brought forward the Venusaur ball and placed it on the table. Blue examined it for a long time. Longing. She'd put that memory on hold to move forward — not because she no longer longed for it.

"Thank you."

She turned to Red, then to Gold/Richter.

“And to you. Very brave. Really.”

Gold/Richter felt out of place. He cleared his throat.

“You’re welcome. Should I step out?”

“No. We’re in your debt. A reward. A partial one.”

“All right,” he said, without a hint of pretence. “I’d never have managed it. No doubt.”

“I doubt my influence is quite that all-powerful…”

He took a step back, awkwardly, almost as if to disappear.

Red continued, in a lower voice, his eyes still fixed on the ball:

“Your experiments were brutal. Those who stay with us don’t always have a sensible reason. I survived. I held out.”

Blue nodded.

BGM: “EP05 S02 24:07 25:37”

“Yes. Some who walk away do not do so out of malice. It is the quality that counts. The dedication. As for me, I stayed. Neither toxic nor useful. That is all. I must have done some crazy things…”

Red and Green remembered at the same time. The awkwardness they had felt back then returned for a moment.

“I don’t regret it,” she continued. “Nor the outcome. It’s just… I’m bearing the consequences. The gossip. Red — I’m not holding a grudge. I wish you happiness. I’m not casting you aside. But all these gestures sometimes confuse me. Whether it’s lingering affection. Or a justification. My horizons are limited. I’m aware of that. The paths aren’t any easier. They’re weighed down. The consequences of not being as brilliant as you. I suppose…’

Red shook his head.

“...No. You’ve done more than you realise.”

“Don’t bother. It’s a pointless consolation.”

“You’re under no illusions,” he said. Exactly. “To overcome your projection, you’ve already exhausted your reserves dealing with the other person. Your limits. That’s all.”

A pang of sorrow washed over her. Brief. Without drama.

Red glanced at Gold/Richter, then turned back to her.

“Gold/Richter isn’t as strong as me or Green. His burdens, for the role, are no lighter. This shortcoming—lucidity, competence—doesn’t bring us relief. It weighs us down. It forces us to face our own limits. It frustrated you. It made you devote yourself too much. Shame. Powerlessness. Oak, Green, me: we didn’t escape it either.”

Gold/Richter remembered Chris/Maria. The blunders. He stood there, uncomfortable, without objecting.

“You’re not blinded by your own projections,” Red continued. “Nor by your flaws. Nor by your limitations. It made you overlook the happiness you created yourself.”

BGM: ‘A Third Soul’ 00:00–01:30

An anonymous touch beneath Blue’s ribs. Red continued:

“I’m not belittling happiness. It isn’t everywhere. It isn’t easy. Even when we create it ourselves, sometimes we overlook it…”

He continued, more slowly.

“You wouldn’t have cared so much for Green if you’d been able to choose Squirtle. You would have thought you loved the one who would never have reciprocated. And you would have missed out on the one who was meant for you. By choosing Bulbasaur, you didn’t lose the blue. The water. You shared it. Shaped it together with the other.”

Blue blinked. So did Green. Gold/Richter listened as one might listen to a language that’s a little too precise. Red wouldn’t stop:

‘Green didn’t take on his colour,’ said Red. ‘Whilst he was losing his way, the water softened the mistakes. Without letting them run their course. Neither he nor I were unrestrained. For there was only us. Including a third soul. Your power wasn’t enough. It was essential. Its true nature remained with you. A complex bond. Difficult. To learn. Precious, in the end.”

Green lowered his eyes. A submissive embarrassment. He didn’t object. Red continued:

“I think that is why you did not give away your Pokémon. You lent it out. I did not take Blastoise. Venusaur. A blessing. Not just from you. From him too. So I came back. You are right: the local bond must be taken seriously. We cannot see clearly without the others. Our generation. The other one.”

She clenched the ball. A sidelong glance at Green.

“You often emphasised my independence,” Red continued. “From home. You’re wrong. My bond with Misty is strong. It wasn’t strong enough back then. If you hadn’t done that crazy thing—that paradoxical encouragement—I would have lost to Green. Without that bond from home. Not even love. Don’t underestimate your part in it.”

Blue did not reply. Neither did Green. Gold/Richter remained silent.

Red searched for the right words one last time, then blurted out, without beating about the bush:

“I just want to say this. I’m grateful to you, Blue. Someone like me has lasted this long thanks to devoted people like you. Limited powers. Responsibilities taken on. Even if they didn’t have to push themselves so hard.”

He paused. His voice softened.

“All I want is for you to be happy. Without shame. With the one you truly care about.”

She accepted it almost entire ball. There weren’t many tears. Resigned. Mature. Elegant. An acceptance. She let them flow so that she could finally hold onto these feelings without holding them back so much.

The air around them held the petals. Nothing else needed to fall.

End of scene

Scene — Now I Have Experienced It

Pallet Town— laboratory, then the garden, autumn twilight

The office was cluttered but not untidy. Warrants. Files. A professional clutter. Oak went about his business as usual, with that now routine formality. Something, however, troubled him — a premonition that wasn't entirely bad, cryptic, difficult to unravel in full consciousness. On the table, cold tea at the bottom of a cup, light sweets already nibbled at, yet still neatly arranged.

He recalled, in fragments, the utensils lent to Gold/Richter. A glimmer of hope. He did not pin his hopes on it. He left it to fate. Unlikely to come to fruition, as far as he knew. He was neither going to overburden the lad nor underestimate him. He took his pelisse. The image faded away before the door.

—

BGM 'EP01S02 12:00–13:54'

The garden, in September, was colder. Petals drifted gently. No epitaph. No grave. Yet there was something of a cemetery about the air — a liturgical gloom, more imagined than real. A glimmer of liveliness, all the same, in the low-hanging branches.

Oak stopped as one stops before a gravestone. He pondered this dissonance. For a moment, the world receded.

Footsteps. His own speculation delayed the sound of them. As soon as they were too close, he heard them. He turned round.

Red. Gold/Richter, standing a little behind him.

The stupor lasted a few seconds. Then his face conveyed too many things at once: a wish fulfilled, a putative redemption, a fleeting joy. Red saw it.

Red's serene smile brought back something distressing. Oak concealed it. His expression grew harsher — like a refusal to accept what one did not deserve. Red's smile vanished. He had understood.

Oak addressed, first, the one standing further away.

'By all accounts, you've made good use of my tools… What's the verdict…?'

Gold/Richter sensed the intent behind the question. It robbed him of some of his joy.

"Yes," he said. "Without them, I would never have managed it. Thank you so very much, Professor."

"My heartfelt congratulations… on your magnanimous selflessness. Almost like volunteering."

The evasion was fleeting. Most would not have noticed it. Red picked up on it. A brief flicker of despondency. Oak knew he could not lead two teenagers astray for long. That realisation does not absolve him.

"Yet you're still staying in Kanto," he continued, addressing Gold/Richter. "Even here. It doesn't quite add up."

Red finally spoke.

“He’s accompanying me. Under my authority.”

The evasion had become evasive. Oak accepted it — trust and doubt, side by side.

‘What do you mean?’ he asked. His tone was steady.

“Lack of confidence. Seen a bit of a mess. Chronic.”

“Hard to believe that could hold you back. At your level…”

Red faltered. Oak saw it. He tried to spare him.

“Can you come back as if it were your home…?”

He already looked as if he were leaving.

“I want to sort out a few things,” said Red. “Unresolved matters.”

“Can’t we just pretend nothing ever happened? There are no more direct enemies. Or dragons. Like in a classic ending.”

“We can’t pretend that. If I want to come back to us. Or keep the relationship going.”

Oak looked him straight in the eye.

“Please do.”

“I’m listening,” said Oak.

A touch of sternness once more, to discourage, despite his acceptance.

“You don’t have to blame yourself,” said Red. “If something crosses your mind.”

It was true. Oak heard it as a white lie.

“I don’t need to clear my conscience.”

‘Some faults, if they exist, cannot always be avoided, even against one’s will. If the proverbs are true, one can be forgiven if one repents. I hope so.’

This kindness—seemingly selective—brought a smile to Oak’s face. Red had not expected it.

“Can anyone be redeemed so easily? Almost for free? If everything could be sorted out that way, faith in God would be a lucrative business. Thanks for your offer.”

“But would He be pleased with that…?” asked Red.

“The problem,” said Oak, “is whether you can clear all your debts without acknowledging the consequences. Adults aren’t role models like that. No responsibility.”

The weight of it all bore down on him.

“I do not envy you for having pushed me beyond my limits, in certain situations. I do not make a show of it. But to receive such sincere, unvarnished praise from one of my pupils, at such a cruel hour — it was almost a condemnation. Ironic. In spite of yourself.”

“I’ve come back,” said Red. “Not even unscathed. Thanks to the Lord. I hope.”

“Whilst my privilege led me to misjudge His wisdom. The burdens a young man like you had to bear. After your exile, your absence made me feel as though I’d killed a teenager with my own hands. Without exaggeration. I cannot absolve myself of that.”

Red let the words sink in.

“…Professor. I’ve realised… that we can’t love other children as we love our own. Not so easily.”

That cut through something.

“It’s not altruism,” added Red. “I suffered. But I’m glad Green wasn’t abandoned. Thanks to the blood.”

A vague sense of guilt crept over Oak. Red continued.

BGM ‘A World to Win’ 00:47–end

“Green… he isn’t as capable as you. Not both a warrior and a scholar. Not the same courage, the same curiosity. He’s good at passing things on. It takes time to discover his genius. Without that bond, we probably wouldn’t have tolerated him. Wouldn’t have expected him. Beings like him, like Gold/Richter, are delicate. They sometimes survive thanks to an injustice. I’m delighted. Grateful. Truly.”

‘A child who appreciates me so much,’ murmured Oak. ‘Lucidity. Devotion. Blindness. He’s telling me all this. What irony.’

He had not wished to abandon Green. The realisation was undeniable, though. A sense of resignation.

“I respect you,” said Red. “Revere you? Certainly not.”

Oak focused his attention more intently.

“My deference was vague. Not blind. You have unwittingly contributed to my adversity. All too often we make serious mistakes, with the best of intentions. Not always justifiable. Not always forgivable. So many people have not escaped this fate. Even with vigilance. With sincerity. With lucidity. They come up against their own mortality. We want to protect those we love. We cannot avoid hurting them. You. Gold/Richter. Blue. Me. I have accepted this reality. I shall not hold it against you. Not out of naivety.”

Oak slumped. Almost to his knees, without actually falling.

‘Science is neutral in itself,’ continued Red. ‘But like those with no blood ties, most are too fragile in the face of it. Its rationality. Its logic. Its eloquence. Too overpowering. Our approach is too binary: to reject it out of pride, or to believe in it blindly. Many wise men do not even know how to find a compromise. You, perhaps, were not one of those types. You had the courage, the foresight, the initiative, to anticipate the risk — and to humanise it. That is why I respect you.”

Gold/Richter, standing back, did not move.

‘My words: “This world is imperfect, but it is also preserved by you.” You did not foresee certain eventualities. The burdens of ordinary children. Your research, exploited by Giovanni. Green nearly desecrated serious matters. Not everything. If anyone else had been in your place, without your bravery, without your qualities, science would have run amok. The world would have collapsed. The

Old Man Coyote would have won. Not enough to save us from the wounds. From the scars. Enough against annihilation. Against sin."

Oak listened. Feelings that came too late, indescribable. He couldn't bring himself to take pride in the price paid. He simply listened some more.

"I've simply come to realise… that great heroes are imperfect. Contrary to what is generally believed. You are the hero of the first generation."

He continued, more quietly.

"God's cruel wisdom… If the Old Man Coyote used your research to corrupt, Providence did the same. It used you to save. To reward loyalty. The Old Man Coyote need only channel inherent vices. For Him, it is enough to recycle inherent virtues. Even with flaws."

Oak's eyes grew moist. A few lingering tears. Not a flood. They weren't really flowing. They were simply there.

"I have nothing to forgive you for," said Red. "Thanks to your learning, your inventions, your knowledge, I've been able to protect my own. I'm indebted to you. Truly. You'll always be my mentor."

Something akin to a chronic burden shifted. The outpouring, however, continued.

"I wish I could be more than just your mentor…" said Oak.

Red accepted the incomplete, imperfect wish with kindness.

"Before, I had realised how merciful God is. Now, I have experienced it."

Gold/Richter, still standing back, smiled. Understanding. Indulgent. The petals, all around them, had not ceased to fall.

End of scene

Scene — Destined for Potential Rather Than Death

Pallet Town — Oak's laboratory, dusk

The office still smelled of paper and cold tea. Mewtwo was already there. An almost dignified joy flitted across his features — a sense of knowledge, a rare complacency.

Red and Gold/Richter entered. The presence hardly surprised them. The distance between them was short. It was not non-existent.

The voice came without a mouth. Telepathy. Almost on equal terms.

'It's been a while, Red. And several months, Gold/Richter.'

They felt as though a bond of trust had just been forged.

Gold/Richter remained reserved, powerless.

"You've intercepted us…"

As if nothing could be hidden.

“First, I spotted you arriving,” said Mewtwo. “Then I refused to miss out on this part.

It wasn’t out of obsessive curiosity. When humans engage with this level of sophistication… the potential is infinite. Even I need to keep up to date. To adapt. So as not to become too outdated.”

He spoke like an uncle. Not just like a Legendary.

Red nodded.

‘You’ve been observing our convention, I take it.’

“Yes. Even if it was superfluous. Or more in the style of Giovanni. So much the better. You’ll be able to devote yourself to other areas. More constructive ones.”

An intimate smile passed between the three of them.

Gold/Richter stepped forward slightly.

BGM “EP08 S02 15:45 – 16:18”

“Mewtwo… I’ve come to thank you for your comfort. It’s been more helpful than your strength alone. Truly. Your approval of the bond without blood.”

“Mew would have wanted to encourage you then, I suppose.”

A clumsy, shared moment of joy.

“And also to bid you farewell,” added Gold/Richter.

It did not weigh upon him at all.

‘Do not fret. Red has returned. I have no cause to visit Kanto any longer. Not of late, at any rate.’

“Enjoy your life,” said Mewtwo. “Every moment. Human life is fleeting.”

Gold/Richter smiled. Irony. Warmth. Family.

“Take care of yourself. Do not let yourself be consumed by the sadness of our departures. From this world. Not for the sake of foolish humans.”

Mewtwo sensed the subtext, the warmth that masked melancholy, and let nothing show on his face.

“I shall learn to regard you as destined for potential. Rather than for death.”

A foreboding sadness, held in check. Red and Gold/Richter replied with a solemn smile. Friendly. Enough.

End of scene

Scene — Becoming Your Son Again

Pallet — Red’s house

BGM ‘Richter My Friend’

The twilight lingered on the tablecloth. The mother had offered Gold/Richter a cup. He maintained a matter-of-fact demeanour, without pretence. She couldn't quite picture his journey. She didn't dare to probe.

'I'm here to say goodbye to you,' said Gold/Richter.

She could not hide her disappointment. She did not complain about it. She did not blame him.

Gold/Richter pressed on, undaunted by her disappointment.

'And just to let you know… you could clean his room less often. Starting straight away.'

She didn't follow. There were no clues.

To welcome him, she'd forgotten to lock the door. A teenager walked in.

At that moment, she realised.

It was Red.

Gold/Richter had not intended to spoil the surprise for him. It was Red's idea. Red did not stride in as he once would, even though this was his home. Time weighed heavier than the threshold.

'Good evening, Mum.'

She couldn't find the words. She waited. She wasn't ready.

Red tried to break through the barrier.

"I'm back… I've been able to simply become your son again…"

Her face gave her away. The shock. Those words moved her just as much. A commonplace wish. An everyday one. Nothing out of the ordinary. Granted.

You could see the tears welling up. You did not see them.

Cut.

End of scene

Scene — Every True Happiness in Its Own Way

Pallet — the quay, autumn twilight

The wind was blowing in from the sea. The air smelled of salt and wet wood. Cold ash and wet wood. On one side of the Pallet Town quay, Red, Misty, Blue, Green and Lance had almost lined up, forming a motionless guard of honour. A sense of camaraderie—sober, exclusive—manifested without the slightest verbal outpouring.

On the other side, Gold/Richter and Eusine stood ready to board, their suitcases set on the ground. Fearow had landed heavily on the pile of luggage—too many bags for human arms to carry, a simple, rational way of conserving energy. Haunter had also set its load down on the ground, stepping back slightly. Gold/Richter then felt a vague sense of unease at this display of solidarity, this collective deference he had not asked for:

BGM ‘EP05 S01 18:34 – 19:24’

‘I wasn’t expecting such a warm send-off…’

Misty nodded.

“It’s only right, given all you’ve done for us, Gold/Richter. We didn’t take it for granted. We hadn’t managed to thank you properly.”

He took it in. A sigh. A sense of relief.

“I’m too tired from the take-off to carry all this. It’s no trouble at all for you to come with me, Mr Eusine.”

Eusine glanced sideways, removing his white coat

“Our paths merely align,” said Eusine. “I prefer company to solitude.”

His tone was humble, stripped of its former poetic emphasis. Gold/Richter accepted this.

Lance took a step forward.

“I represent the rest of the League. And to let you know… the Professor is considering democratising the Pokédex.”

Gold/Richter instantly reverted to his role as the vigilant inspector, the system’s neurologist.

“That is a drastic proposal,” Lance continued. “It would potentially ease your burdens. But the consequences for the masses remain irreversible. The preparations will have to be carried out with even greater rigour.”

He did not take the suggestion lightly.

Green spoke up, his face calm, his hands in his pockets.

“Do not fret. He is concentrating on revising Dr Fuji’s posthumous thesis. We can suspend the protocol in the meantime.”

Gold/Richter remained pensive for a moment, his thoughts turning to his memories of Kanto.

BGM “Alone for Many Years”

“…It is strange. After the external challenges, the internal ones are intensifying. If we had arrested Apollo, we would have been content with the power of the law alone. And with the stagnation of our times. How can I explain it…?”

Red replied without raising his voice, breaking his silence with matter-of-fact sobriety.

“It is not a universal law. It is too late for his redemption. But his discernment, that, was spontaneous. His very existence still serves as a warning. Undoubtedly.”

A look of gloom crossed Gold/Richter’s face.

“Yes. The others: dissecting their misdeeds, yes. Their lives… unthinkable. They are almost incorrigible. Too pathetic. We can only bring them to justice.”

A clumsy, collective joy swept through the platform.

Gold/Richter continued, in a lower voice.

“It’s paradoxical. It’s claimed that evil targets those who obey. Those who don’t question. Those who don’t think. A form of narcissism. An aristocratic display of ostentation. It would be enough to think without becoming a threat — selectively — to be predictable. Manipulable. These aristocrats of thought cannot even grasp these primitive logics…”

‘Did he instil that idea in you…?’ asked Red.

“Yes. Apollo was pragmatic. Budget-minded. Paradoxically, he reveals that those who believe themselves to be good and frugal are often the greatest wasters. The greatest hypocrites. Ideology. Charisma. Social climbing. Superiority. Victimisation. Pure waste. Luxuries. Because those who adopt a performative frugality whilst in poverty would squander in abundance… Intrinsic savagery. Deep-rooted. I suppose.”

They smiled. No one objected. No one quite knew how to deal with this precocious intellect. They tried not to discourage him. To treat him normally. Yet they could see the constructive side of it.

“What do you plan to do from now on?” asked Red.

“Red. We’ve gained our strength. Not enough. We’ll need more. Like an education.”

He paused.

BGM ‘The Belmont Family’

“Besides, I just want to make the most of my life. As I owe it to Chris/Maria.”

A resonance spread out from Red. A warm silence.

‘…Nevertheless. Is that true…? All happy people are alike, whilst every unhappy person is unhappy in their own way… Why don’t I share in it…?’

The younger brother’s scepticism served to lighten the mood, to break the overly philosophical tone of their reflections. Eusine replied first, a sardonic smile playing on his lips:

“If happiness is simulated, programmed by the technocracy and selectively defined by the masses, then yes, they do all resemble one another, indeed…”

“Would we only realise that by experiencing unhappiness…?” asked Red. “Is that it…?”

Blue spoke, without raising her voice.

“But if happiness isn’t free, if it comes at a price, if it has been forged through wounds and scars — then everyone who is happy is so in their own way. More diverse than unhappiness.”

The words stirred the group as one.

“…Yes,” concluded Gold/Richter. “Life is worthy. It isn’t precious in itself. It’s only precious on the condition that it can harbour and bring happiness. Because it truly fulfils us…”

The boat drew alongside the quay and moored in silence. Haunter, Fearow, Gold/Richter and Eusine lifted the luggage with professional efficiency.

‘Eusine,’ Red blurted out before the gangway was withdrawn

He started at being addressed.

‘We shall ensure that Kanto one day deserves a man of your stature,’ said Red, his gaze intense. ‘Even if it is not in this lifetime.’

Eusine showed no sign of it. No pride. He merely nodded in agreement.

“The light is already emerging…”

A brief compliment. For Kanto, a comfort. A warmth.

Gold/Richter turned towards them.

“We’ll meet again one day. Grant me a respite for now.”

“You’d be one of the reasons to travel through Johto,” replied Red. “In the meantime, make the most of your happiness. And your peace. For they are fleeting, and so precious.”

The wind carried the salt once more. The boat did not wait any longer.

End of scene

Final Scene — ‘Vedro con mio diletto’

Pallet — the quay

Gold/Richter accepted the blessing. He turned round.

Eusine was already waiting for him. Fearow took the overflow. Haunter lifted what was left. They climbed the ship’s stairs. The planks creaked beneath their feet. Red and Misty did not move. The parting was temporary. The longing, however, was not.

The track began.

BGM ‘Vedro con mio diletto’ 00:00–00:16

The boat pulled away from the quay. The salty air grew more expansive. The four figures grew smaller in the eyes of those left behind.

The laboratory

BGM ‘Vedro con mio diletto’ 00:16–00:34

Oak was making notes. Fuji’s thesis. The substance held up; it was the form that was the problem — formats, duplicates, a formality that should not have had to be repeated with every publication. Pedantic. Retroactive. That troubled him more than the content.

Agatha, sitting beside him, pretended to be reading less serious magazines. Without much enthusiasm. She was watching him all the same. She had glimpsed, vaguely, a release — a chronic burden finally lifting. She smiled.

Through the window, Mewtwo. No ultimate joy. No paranoia. Just vigilance, in the face of a future that was already fickle.

A field, somewhere in Kanto

BGM ‘Vedro con mio diletto’ 00:34–00:54

Giovanni was dressed like a drifter. Serious. His charisma intact. His caution, too. The opponent, this time, was clear.

Silver appeared in stages. He seemed to have nothing left to lose. The outcome weighed heavily on him. He had adapted to it without frivolity. His movements were more fluid than in the days when tenacity alone sufficed. It wasn’t just the Dex. It was a return to form. His conscientiousness had not been sacrificed. Every tiny gesture spoke of it: a sound reason to persevere.

Nothing about Giovanni escaped his notice any longer — not even the tiniest movement. Giovanni took note of it. Something shifted within him. He did not show it. Seniority still held the upper hand.

A ball. Giovanni. Another, almost parallel, crisper than before. The rally began.

Cut.

A platform. Who knows where.

BGM ‘Vedro con mio diletto’ 00:54–01:12

A labourer was walking at his leisure. Then terror—visceral. Houndoom. Vampiric. Ancient. A contained hostility. One thought he was about to attack. A dissonance followed: this Pokémon was terrifying; it did not really wish to prey on anyone.

Then the labourer saw the trainer. His dread intensified. Not that the man was any more monstrous. He was, by most standards, not quite human — and he was the source. Apollo. Bureaucratic. Sharp. Spectral. Graceful. Crisp. He didn’t seem to be scheming. He seemed to *be upholding* an image. A warning. A lesson exposed to oblivion.

He almost froze. Simply standing there was enough. The labourer found it hard to believe that such a being could walk amongst the everyday. Apollo looked away. Not out of kindness. Out of calculation: there was no need to frighten him any further. His presence did the job.

Pallet — the boat already far away

BGM ‘Vedro con mio diletto’ 01:12–01:36

He could still be seen. Those on the quay were watching.

Feathers. First one. Then too many. Murkrow. They had no business being here. They circled like vultures, unhurried, as if they were monopolising time.

The outline became clearer. The Old Man Coyote. Sinister. Treacherous. He was watching the boat *and* the quay. No relentlessness. He was taking stock of his obstacles. He was taking stock of them. Time cost him nothing. These threats were fleeting. A protocol could be halted. He would not be subjected to any subsequent debacle. He was not hiding in a castle. He was the castle. He coexisted with time. The Old Man Coyote is depicted as something that time has not erased.

The Murkrow widened the circle. The silhouette grew larger. A cloak. A god of death, for those who would believe in him.

He smiled. No joy. No sadism. A pretence — to make us believe in a human motive. A projection. A trap. The smile adds no emotion. It **borrows** ours. Joy, sadism: motives we know how to read. The moment we believe it, we fall into its trap — feigned affinity, a readable face, a visceral trance (fear, hatred, fascination). It plays on this reflex: *a face must want something from us*. It is not that it has a hidden human soul. It is that it **mimics** enough to make our filters misjudge the situation.

It had no disdain for light. It acted by nature. To survive. To exist. True to primitive, ritualised desires. This took nothing away from its intelligence: it adapted, acculturated itself, too agile for us. Its true terror was not that it was invincible. It was our recklessness. Even for a moment. An ominous wisdom. Inexhaustible. You cannot eliminate it. You take shelter. You refuse to give it a foothold.

That feigned smile was enough to serve as a reminder.

Goldenrod — a park

BGM 'Vedro con mio diletto' 01:36–01:48

Miniskirt Krise. Birdkeeper Bryan. Hoothoot. Jigglypuff. A bench.

Juggler Mike. Empty-handed. One degree. Voltorb. Then the creature slid smoothly down his arm. At first, we thought it was a trick. It was simply his craft.

No whistles. No raucous applause. An inner admiration, plain enough for those who knew how to look. Krise and Bryan weren't overwhelmed. Mike didn't disappoint them. He wasn't one for that sort of thing. He exuded a sense of discipline. A sense of elevation. The continuity of one day, then the next.

Ecruteak — the theatre

BGM 'Vedro con mio diletto' 01:48–02:00

Morty watched in silence. Deference.

The Kimono Girls were dancing. Slow. Austere. Elegant. Unhurried. Intergenerational. Imperfect. Not a dogma. An admonition without glorification.

Art was not neutral. Nor was it manipulative. A companion. Gold/Richter's advice had already slipped into the norm, stealthily. A living debt. A just gratitude. They would hold on until his return — and beyond.

New Bark — Chris/Maria's room

BGM 'Vedro con mio diletto' 02:00–02:12

He was coming home today. She knew it. The impatience. The reconciliation she longed for.

The future was thorny. She wasn't shying away from it. She'd prepared herself for it. Only: she'd already returned to city life. He hadn't yet. The disconnect bothered her. A sudden sense of caution. A restrained blush. She wasn't running away. Welcoming him back would come at a cost. Not in terms of money: in terms of life.

The ship in the evening

BGM « Vedro con mio diletto » 02:12–02:24

Gold/Richter was seated. Outside, the scenery was changing. His nerves prevented him from enjoying it.

He'd hoped for something ordinary with her. Not a penance. A bond. A need. A mutual connection. But everything that had happened remained visceral. He'd have to come to terms with it. Come to terms with it. He looked out at the water to quell his anxiety.

On the deck, Eusine. The night revealed almost nothing. He looked out all the same. It was as if he were singing. The craft held him fast. Neither quite of this world, nor quite of another.

Viridian — home

Background music: 'Vedro con mio diletto' 02:24–02:38

Daily life had resumed. Green at the window, unable to make out anything clearly. Blue, reading — an effective pastime.

A sense of melancholy lingered. It no longer held her back quite so much. It had become part of him. The formless barrier had fallen. A distance remained. Not a barrier. Just enough to let the bond endure without burning it out.

Her movements had the ease of a woman who'd been married for years. Incredible for her age. Well-suited to enduring.

Green approached. She saw him. Her lips, like a support. A fulcrum. Not a spectacle. She offered no display of passion. She did not refuse. Enough to see that she needed it.

Pallet — Red's house

BGM 'Vedro con mio diletto' 02:38–02:52

Misty, the guest room. The weariness of the gym. That of the quay. Clinging to the bed. Not yet asleep. Remnants.

Her mother looked as though her wish had been granted. She could have poured her heart out. She spared herself that. And Red, too. He'd never lost everything. Just access. To her. To Misty. He was making sure of the resettlement — at least within this circle.

The strangeness, outside of that, lingered. Not particularly disturbing. He could entrust it to the rhythm. The burdens were no longer confined to Kanto.

The Poké Gear. Green. Blue. Misty. Gold/Richter. The name appeared on the screen. He paused. No panic. He didn't call. He looked. He imagined.

New Bark — the platform, at night

BGM 'Vedro con mio diletto' 02:52–03:09

The ship was very close. The planks of New Bark Town's quay came into view in the low-angled light. Almost docked.

Chris/Maria was already there.

From the upper deck, Gold/Richter and Eusine spotted her, visible to the eye long before she was within walking distance.

Their gazes met. Eusine, quietly to himself, recalled an old salon saying — *'youth is a rare, enviable commodity…'* — but it was now nothing more than an affectionate tease in his mind, a silent blessing. The paths ahead would remain thorny. They had made it through. That was what mattered.

Chris/Maria scrutinised Gold/Richter's face, her gaze intense. The docking was taking too long for their contained impatience.

She had never lacked passion, but time, the twists and turns of life, and the burden of responsibility had wisely tempered her. Not Providence — merely a rigorous discipline. Her passion had transformed into constant vigilance, a discipline of the soul, a just and salvific rigour.

The final shot lingered on Gold/Richter's face.

A serious, mature tenderness, refined by the long vigil. Romantic, yes — like Chris/Maria's gaze, but for slightly different, darker reasons. He had lived at the very heart of the core; he knew the exact cost of human folly and the price of sacrifice. All this still weighed heavily on him, but he was already adapting, taking care that nothing of that deadly past should desecrate the ordinary life that was at last beginning.

He knew how delicate peace was. How fragile happiness was. Precious for that very reason.

He was settling into the ordinary, never again taking it for granted.

The final note. Cut.

End of the series

Close of episode — and of the series

Totals

≈ 15,700 words · 42 pp. A4 · read aloud ≈ 105 min.

Pass 1/3 — still open

Coyote metalepsis outside the body. Gold/Richter only. was / continued / Insolent. Goldenrod. Titles outside durations. Notes entered here. P1: hunting crop; imprecation; Blue she/her at the quay and at Viridian; bearing, not cross-dresser; prefecture; soundless; cane; democratising the Pokédex; A Third Soul (piece) ≠ The Third Soul (scene).

Version notes

2026-09-24 — EN-GB apparatus after P1. Intermittent Alpine comparisons. Author filled. Episode title = the piece (exception). Body calibration of the EN script still to be applied.

The series

Episodes 01–15 calibrated at pass 1/3. The author applies and archives. The Coyote is not concluded: it coexists.

Open for what follows

The Coyote still · the Dex to be democratised · fragile happiness · ordinary life at New Bark.

BGM credits

Nocturne pieces: Trevor Morris & Trey Toy. Traces: duration only. Vedro con mio diletto: the Handel/Vivaldi air as used in the series montage.